

Adaptation and Appropriation

Cite as: Martin Paul Eve, "Adaptation and Appropriation", *eve.gd: Martin Paul Eve*, January 04, 2022, <https://doi.org/10.59348/m5myx-dy885>.



This post forms part of my '[aspects of the novel](#)' collection. Please do note that these entries, which may appear basic, are simply my own notes on the subject. The original encyclopaedia articles are far more comprehensive and worth consulting.

The novel is intricately bound to ideas of intertextuality. Many novels explicitly cite other works (consider Dickens citing Shakespeare in *Nicholas Nickleby* or George Eliot's [many epigraphs](#)).

The novel has also historically worked to bring voice to marginalized figures. For instance, Jean Rhys's *Wide Sargasso Sea* (1966) gives the perspective of Bertha Mason in *Jane Eyre* while J. M. Coetzee's *Foe* (1986) takes a fresh angle on *Robinson Crusoe*. Sena Jeter Naslund crafts a story, *Ahab's Wife* (1999), from fleeting mentions of Captain Ahab's off-stage family in *Moby-Dick*. Marina Warner's 1992 *Indigo* reimagines *The Tempest* from a freshly re-gendered perspective. Peter Carey's *Jack Maggs* (1997) gives a voice to Magwitch from Dickens's *Great Expectations*.

So-called shadow-texts occur in which novels echo others. Zadie Smith has called her *On Beauty* (2005) a reworking of *Howard's End*. Will Self's *Dorian* (2002) rewrites *A Picture of Dorian Gray*. Joyce's *Ulysses* (1922) famously riffs on Homer and Hamlet.

These appropriations and rewritings are sometimes confused with plagiarism; Graham Swift's *Last Orders* (1996) pays homage to Faulkner's *As I Lay Dying* (1930), but some contemporary readers simply saw Swift's re-use as copying and unoriginal.

Novels themselves, of course, are frequently adapted to other media. Film and televisual remakes are common.

Further reading: Sanders, Julie, 'Adaptation/Appropriation', in *The Encyclopedia of the Novel*, ed. by Peter Melville Logan, Olakunle George, Susan Hegeman, and Efraín Kristal (Malden, MA: Wiley-Blackwell, 2011), pp. 1–9